

Architecture in Everyday Life

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FOR AN ENTERPRISE THAT EXALTS THE CONCRETE, the study of everyday life is remarkably vague about its object. The everyday comprises “seemingly unimportant activities.”¹ Or it is “a set of functions which connect and join together systems that might appear to be distinct.”² Or it is that which is leftover, which falls outside of or runs counter to the scrutiny of power or officialdom. It is an Other of some sort, better defined by what it is not than by what it is.

The same vagueness about the nature of everyday life plagues architecture. For one architect, “The everyday is that which remains after one has eliminated all specialized activities.”³ According to another, everyday space lies “in between such defined and physically definable realms as the home, the workplace, and the institution, [it] is the connective tissue that binds everyday lives together.”⁴ But what is this connective tissue? Where can we find it? How do we recognize it? Of what is it made?

Architecture is inescapably concrete and it forms the fabric and the setting of everyday life. Consequently, to approach everyday life through architecture—architecture with a lower-case *a*, understood in its broadest sense to encompass the entire material world (or “cultural landscape”) that people make and think—is to be forced to pin down, in ways too often lacking in theories of the quotidian, the precise ways in which everyday life is experienced and the specifics of its relationships to other aspects of life and landscape. So architecture’s materiality makes it a natural conduit to the specificity of everyday life.

Over the last decade, contemporary theories of everyday life have begun to infiltrate Architecture with a capital *A*—the realm of high design and theory that forms one small corner of the larger world of architecture. The increasingly pervasive commodification and homogenization of life and landscape and the extreme social stratification associated with globalization seem poised to devastate both the cultural landscape and the architectural profession. As the architect Steven Harris noted, “The consideration of everyday life as a critical political construct represents an attempt to suggest an architecture resistant to this commodification/consumption paradigm, a paradigm that has come to dominate contemporary architectural practice” (EA 3).

Architectural exploration of everyday life is closely allied to the work of Henri Lefebvre, who planted the theory of the everyday squarely in architecture's bailiwick. "Everyday life is sustenance, clothing, furnishing, homes, neighbourhoods, environment. . . . Call it material culture if you like, but do not confuse the issue," he wrote (*EL* 21). In particular, his fascination with the spatial nature of social life resonated with a long-established claim that space should be the defining element of a modern Architecture.⁵ Thus architecture's discovery of Lefebvre following the English-language publication of *The Production of Space* (1991) helped to rehabilitate space after a quarter-century of the postmodern elevation of representation and language over space and materiality.⁶ Lefebvre framed his interest in space and the everyday as part of his lifelong project to examine the meaning of modernity, and modernity—what it means to be modern, what a modern Architecture might be—is also a central strain in twentieth-century architectural discourse.

In current architectural history, theory, and practice, then, discussion of the everyday takes place at the intersection of architecture and Architecture—of the study of the material settings of human life and of the narrower concerns of professional design. In the first part of this essay I will examine some ways that theories of the everyday have been used to reflect upon goals and practices in the study and making of architecture. The idea of the everyday has pushed architectural thought in important new directions, but those directions have been limited both by weaknesses in the original theories and by misreadings prompted by the intellectual history and preoccupations of Architecture. In particular, theories of the everyday have reinforced an Architectural habit of dichotomous and hierarchical thinking about the landscape. In addition, architectural writers have fit their thinking about everyday life into the discourse model that has dominated Architectural theory for thirty years. In the second part of the essay I will present an alternate way of thinking about the everyday that transcends these problems by drawing on the materiality of landscape and by grounding everyday life in bodily practice.

I

Unlike, say, literary critics or sociologists, who study the works, actions, and values of other people at a distance, builders intervene directly in everyday life. This means that architects must examine their own professional practices and social identities as well as those of the people for whom they build. This habit of self-scrutiny long antedated Architectural interest in the everyday, so called. Since the beginnings of

European-American professionalization two centuries ago, architects (expanding that term to include landscape architects and urban designers) have struggled to differentiate themselves from builders and clients and to establish a clear social identity that would give them the cultural authority to dominate the building market and control the shaping of the landscape. They have failed. Many nonarchitects—builders, clients, critics—continue to claim some authoritative knowledge of the field and decline to grant architects the absolute authority they seek. Many of the first professional architects in the United States worked for speculative builders, turning out standardized row-house and storefront plans. Many contemporary architects work for speculative builders, turning out standardized tract-house and office-building plans.⁷

Sociologists tell us that professionalization always requires that one define and control a unique body of expertise that is acknowledged by outsiders.⁸ As Lefebvre put it, “Architects have a trade. They raise the question of architecture’s ‘specificity’ because they want to establish that trade’s claim to legitimacy. Some of them then draw the conclusion that there are such things as ‘architectural space’ and ‘architectural production’ (specific, of course). Whereupon they close their case” (*PS* 104). Architectural discourse turns on a set of dichotomies between Architecture and its lesser Other meant to distinguish architects’ work from the routinized spatial schemes, standardized imagery, and hackneyed tastes of non-professionals. The fundamental distinction between Architecture and “mere building” was first voiced in the nineteenth century and encapsulated in Nikolaus Pevsner’s memorable comparison between a bicycle shed, “a building,” and Lincoln Cathedral, “a piece of architecture.”⁹ Other binaries derive from this original one: “high” or “academic” or “art” architecture versus vernacular architecture, progressive or modern design practices versus traditional or folk ones, elite versus popular aesthetics, art versus craft. In every case, professionally designed works are credited with a self-conscious sophistication, a subtlety, and a depth that are lacking in other kinds of building, which are consequently defined by what they are not. Professionally designed structures constitute *extraordinary* landmarks in a vast expanse of the ordinary.

The dichotomy has not always favored Architecture. Modernist polemicists sometimes praised the non-professional Other as an exemplar of the uncorrupted, unaffected, even spontaneous creativity lost in the over-refined, over-sophisticated world of professional design. For example, Bernard Rudofsky’s *Architecture without Architects*, the record of an exhibition mounted at New York’s Museum of Modern Art in 1964, presented an eclectic array of photographs of “non-pedigreed” architecture as evidence of the intuitive genius of builders who sought only to accommodate the values and everyday lives of their “primitive” or

“traditional” communities in a direct manner. The influential critic Reyner Banham expected Rudofsky’s book to provoke “a real orgy of professional self-abasement.”¹⁰

A few years after *Architecture without Architects* appeared, the architects Robert Venturi and Denise Scott Brown held the architectural profession up to another standard, that of the popular architecture of capitalist America—“Pop” for short—found along its automobile strips and in its mass-built suburbs. They argued that architects working in a commercial society needed to be grounded in the “reality” of lower-middle-class American aesthetic values. Close study of the existing landscape might offer “formal vocabularies for today which are more relevant to people’s diverse needs and more tolerant of the untidinesses of urban life than the ‘rationalist,’ Cartesian formal orders of latter-day Modern architecture.”¹¹ To be in touch with authentic popular values was “a way of being revolutionary for an architect.”¹² Now the Other had moved from the distant shores of Africa and the Mediterranean to the tract houses that surrounded architects’ own home towns.

Everyday-life theory is permeated with congruent binaries. Lefebvre, for example, made an elemental distinction between the “Quotidian” and the “Modern.” He also contrasted the alienated, colonized, “terrorized” everyday life of modernity to the unalienated, natural life of ancient European and Mesoamerican societies as well as to his highly romanticized portrait of the preindustrial European peasantry. So everyday theory appeared to endorse the longstanding bifurcation of Architectural categories. In *Architecture and the Everyday*, the British architects Sarah Wigglesworth and Jeremy Till describe the professional world as “an island” defined by the “self-contained and self-referential languages of architecture.” Surrounding the rarefied terrain of Architecture’s island is the everyday mainland, an important and necessary reference point for architects, but a different territory.¹³ But theories of everyday life also pushed architectural thought a step beyond Architecture/vernacular architecture, modern/traditional, high-style/folk dichotomies in demonstrating that professional designers belong to the everyday world as well as to the elite world of Architecture. For earlier generations, the traditional, the vernacular, and the popular were exotic lands meant to be surveyed, catalogued, analyzed, and mined rather than inhabited. Denise Scott Brown emphasized “the agony in our acceptance of pop”:¹⁴ in her firm’s famous formulation, the popular landscape was “almost [but *only* almost] all right” (LV6). In the end, she wrote, “we are part of a high art, not a folk or popular art, tradition. We use these other traditions, as others have before us, for an artistic reason; but for a social reason as well. . . . There is a social need for architectural high art to learn from and relate to folk and pop traditions

if it is to serve its real clients and do no further harm in the city" (*PO* 37). The idea of the everyday forces us to acknowledge that Architecture is part of architecture, that designers are a part of the everyday world, not explorers from a more civilized society or detached doers *for* clients and *to* cities.

Nevertheless, everyday theories have yet to reveal to architects a satisfactory way to inhabit the everyday world professionally because architects focus on the dualities in the theory while overlooking the ways the categories blur. Despite a certain looseness of exposition that allows one to read the everyday as an Other—as that which is outside, that which is omitted or escapes from the regimentation of the modern world—Lefebvre asserts the mutual dependence and individual incompleteness of the everyday and the modern. They are simultaneous and connected, in Lefebvre's formulation, "two sides of a reality more amazing than fiction: the society of which we are members" (*EL* 24–25). Which was primary and which was secondary depended on which way you turned the single, entwined ball: each "responds and corresponds" to the other (*EL* 24–25).

To insist on a complementarity that blurs the categorical lines is to raise once more the problem of defining the everyday precisely, of saying what its qualities are, and through what particular processes it acts and is acted upon. By failing to define the everyday more precisely, architectural writers leave it in the undifferentiated and negative realm occupied by tradition, the vernacular, and pop. Like those previous Others, the everyday landscape is something that accuses Architecture of its failings. For architect Margaret Crawford, one of the earliest and most eloquent advocates of the everyday, "Everyday space stands in contrast to the carefully planned, officially designated, and often underused spaces of public use that can be found in most American cities" (*IEU* 9). One brims with possibility, the other is a failure. For Steven Harris, "It is anonymous, its anonymity derived from its undated and apparently insignificant quality" (*EA* 3).

The word anonymous is critical, for it evokes another time-honored Architectural dichotomy, between name-brand Architecture as the expression of discrete creative minds and the rote processes of unnamed vernacular or traditional builders guided as well as constrained by communal rather than individual values. The everyday, like the vernacular, is that which is outside the purview of "specialized activities," including Architecture. That is both its virtue and its failing. It cannot even be encompassed by professional media of representation: the planner John Friedmann lamented "the very real difficulties of authentically representing the city of everyday life. . . . The codified languages of maps and statistics are, in the event, quite useless. For meanings are

formed through experience and are shared in the small talk of everyday life. But this talk carries little weight with planners and engineers.”¹⁵ As with Venturi and Scott Brown’s pop aesthetes, the makers and users of the everyday landscape live a life that is simply too large for petty professional categories.

This way of thinking lapses into the populism that Lefebvre feared the study of the everyday life might become, “magnifying the life of the proletariat, of the man in the street—of people who knew how to enjoy themselves, how to get involved, take risks, talk about what they felt and did” (*EL* 37). For Lefebvre the complementary nature of the Quotidian and the Modern mean that neither sphere monopolized power or powerlessness, banality or innovation. Everyday life is *both* a colonized setting of oppression, banality, routine, passivity, and unconsciousness *and* the locus of an ultimate reality and a source of potential liberation: there is “*something extraordinary in its very ordinariness*” (*EL* 37).¹⁶ It is “a lower sphere of meaning” that requires elevation above the ordinary to achieve its potential, but it is also a place where “creative energy is stored in readiness for new creations” (*EL* 14). For Michel de Certeau, another theorist of the everyday whom architects read closely, everyday practice lacks the “organized discourse” of modernity but is a “multifarious and silent ‘reserve’ of procedures” that might eventually undergird a less oppressive society.¹⁷

In his most expansive moments, Lefebvre wrote of the liberated “total man,” who, as Rob Shields has put it, lived “life as an *oeuvre*, a work of art that required the full investment and reconciliation of both body and mind” (*LL* 71). This complete human being inhabited the premodern countryside, where there was no everyday life because all life was unified: “nothing had yet become prosaic, not even the quotidian; the prose and the poetry of life were still identical” (*EL* 29). Total men and women and an unalienated way of life would be recreated through the act of revolution, when modern men and women “*are no longer able or willing to live as before.*”¹⁸

Architecture is inherently conservative. With rare exceptions, architects prefer to build rather than to tear down, to create the enduring rather than the ephemeral, to enforce order rather than to break it. Le Corbusier once posed the question “Architecture or Revolution?” suggesting that Architecture—“amelioration”—could avert revolution—“catastrophe.”¹⁹ Thus architectural writers have studiously ignored Lefebvre’s insistent claims that the alienation and oppression of everyday life in the modern world could only be resolved through revolutionary change.

This argument threatens Architecture’s hierarchies because it makes Architecture and unalienated life incompatible. Lefebvre declines to

allow us to hang on to everyday life as a kind of totem or *aide memoire*. We have a choice, he wrote, between retaining the everyday as a cherished intellectual concept, an object of sentimental contemplation, or abolishing it. Either we “refute the distinctions between philosophical and non-philosophical, superior and inferior, spiritual and material, theoretical and practical, culture and ignorance, and . . . undertake a radical transformation not only of the state and politics, economics, jurisdiction and sociology, but also of everyday life; or [we] revert to metaphysics, Kierkegaardian anxiety and despair and the liberalism Nietzsche strove to overthrow” (EL 14–15). In a specifically architectural context, the meaning of Lefebvre’s challenge is even more provocative: the dichotomies are untenable. Art-architecture strives for the extraordinary, something that would at the least transfigure everyday life symbolically, while Lefebvre demands not transformation but the eradication of the distinction between the extraordinary and the ordinary. There can be no Architecture, only architecture. Lincoln Cathedral and the bicycle shed are parts of the same landscape, fragments of one whole.

So far architects have chosen not to relinquish the distinction between Architecture and the everyday or the position this distinction grants them. While Sarah Wigglesworth and Jeremy Till wish to avoid reifying the everyday by delineating “an alternative aesthetic based on it,” neither do they want “to get caught within the binary trap of remaining immersed in the ordinary. This would lead to the disavowal of architectural knowledge and creativity alike—knowledge because it is associated with the repressive structures of power and expertise, creativity because it is associated with uncritical genius” (EVA 7). Architecture not Revolution.

As a result, when architects try to incorporate the everyday into their work, the results tend to be embarrassingly literal and decorative. They design aesthetically pleasing carts for street vendors to make them acceptable to the powers that be, or they create small public places on leftover bits of land, or they design a house whose form is taken from the reflection of vegetation in a pond on site, or a building meant to disrupt the routines of perception or to mimic the messiness of everyday existence.²⁰

In its commitment to old and new dichotomies, Architecture uses everyday life most confidently and most effectively as a rhetorical strategy—or a tactic, to use Michel de Certeau’s term. Certeau described space as the “proper” (*propre*) domain of power, which manifested itself through spatialized “strategies.” That is, power, “a proprietor, an enterprise, a city, a scientific institution,” manifests itself in a visible territorial order characterized by “organizing discourses.” Where Lefebvre saw everyday life as a colonized space, Certeau imagined it as spaceless and

formless practices without an organizing discourse. It works in time not space, employing *tactics*—short-term raids on power as opposed to strategic assaults from long-established positions. “A tactic insinuates itself into the other’s place, fragmentarily, without taking it over in its entirety. . . . It has at its disposal no base.” Everyday practices are tactical in this sense: they are “victories of the ‘weak’ over the ‘strong’, . . . clever tricks, knowing how to get away with things” (*PEL* xix, 35–36, 48). Everyday practices operate in the interstices that power’s strategies, no matter how all-encompassing they aim to be, cannot master. Everyday life raids institutional fortresses, undermining and challenging their totalizing ambitions. So architecture employs the trope of everyday life to make guerilla raids on the modern landscape, perhaps to redraw some links or to build some new ones, but never to reconstruct it from scratch.

This seems to me to be the import of architect and theorist Joan Ockman’s call for a “minor” and a “major” architecture that would coexist in critical tension. Minor architecture, “defined by deterritorialization, intensified political consciousness, and the anticipatory assemblage of new cultural forces,” would serve as a check on the “*territorial, apolitical, and conservative of the status quo, or normative*” major architecture. “[T]hat which is major is constantly redefining itself in relation to that which is minor, and that which is minor is always potentially challenging or hybridizing that which is major.”²¹ This is close to Certeau’s concept of strategies and tactics. Major architecture is constantly subject to raids by the minor and so must adjust its premises and its strategies to account for them. The use of the everyday as a kind of rhetorical device that grounds a politically charged critique of Architectural process further echoes Certeau’s vision of language as the principal battleground on which strategy and tactics clash.

In a similar mood, Margaret Crawford envisions an Architecture in touch with everyday life that could help channel frustrated desires into a political language that would “make a new set of personal and collective demands on the social order. Therefore the practices of everyday urbanism should inevitably lead to social change, not via abstract political ideologies imposed from outside, but instead through specific concerns that arise from the lived experience of different individuals and groups in the city” (IEU 13).

Nevertheless, neither Crawford’s arguments nor Ockman’s nor indeed those of any architectural theorist of the everyday, give adequate attention to the physicality of everyday life or to the materiality of Architecture. Lefebvre warned that language “makes everyday life, is everyday life, disguises and conceals it, hiding it behind the ornaments of rhetoric and make-believe, so that, in the course of everyday life,

language and linguistic relations become *denials* of everyday life" (*EL* 120–21). Although the architectural advocates of the everyday call for a practice grounded in "reality" rather than in "abstract theory," theirs remains a rhetorical rather than an action-based model.

II

Architecture took its curious turn toward rhetorical models around 1970. In their seminal *Learning from Las Vegas: The Forgotten Symbolism of Architectural Form*, Robert Venturi, Denise Scott Brown, and Steven Izenour attacked the modernist emphasis on space and form for its low "level of content." They directed readers to the Las Vegas strip to see an architecture that was "antispacial . . . an architecture of communications over space" (*LV* 6–8). Good architecture, they claimed, drew on a vocabulary of long-established, conventional signs, most effectively embodied in architectural decoration, to convey its message. *Learning from Las Vegas* was one of the first of a thirty-year succession of treatises that tried to build architectural theory on linguistic analogies. From the semiotic models of the 1970s, through occasional attempts to use Chomskian generative grammar, to the deconstructivists of the 1990s, architects, theorists, and some historians struggled to demonstrate that buildings might be thought of as a kind of language, or as "texts" or "representations."²² One by one these efforts foundered, for in the end no one has ever established what it is, beyond the simplest commercial or social messages ("eat here," "sleep here," "I'm rich," "I'm in the know") that architecture communicates. Even where architecture incorporates imagery or "iconic" qualities, there is no necessary message intended.

Contemporary architectural theorists of the everyday still work within the linguistic model, overlooking a significant, if secondary, strain of everyday-life theory that emphasizes the material nature of ordinary life. Some of the first philosophers and aestheticians to consider the everyday, the Pragmatists and their aesthetic Dada and Surrealist contemporaries, insisted on founding everyday life and its reform in practice, or what is now termed "embodied action." In *Art as Experience*, the Pragmatist philosopher John Dewey argued that "Art is thus prefigured in the very processes of living": it is grounded in ordinary life through the process of grappling with the material world with the aim of producing an object. "Every art does something with some physical material, the body or something outside the body, with or without the use of intervening tools, and with a view to production of something visible, audible, or tangible."²³

While recent architectural theory offers little basis for a materially grounded analysis of everyday life, there are clues to be found in art. As Architecture took the linguistic road, some artists, notably the Minimalist sculptors, moved toward a rigorously material understanding of experience. These artists explored artifactual presence by stripping away notions of empathy, iconography, narrative ("relation") and, by extension, discourse.²⁴ As the critic Charlotte Willard noted at the time, these sculptors "explored typically architectural concerns of 'space, volume, movement, light,'" and, through their choice of scale and setting, the equally architectural issue of corporeal experience.²⁵

In a famous exchange reported by Robert Morris, the sculptor Tony Smith told an interviewer that he hadn't made his six-foot cube *Die* (1962) larger because he "was not making a monument" nor had he made it smaller because he "was not making an object."²⁶ Either choice would have diminished the effect he sought by removing his work from the immediate human realm and reducing it to an object of distanced contemplation. By making it as high as a person, Smith made *Die* a work to be confronted, not looked up to or down on. He gave it a kind of subjectivity to which the viewer was forced to respond. The point, as Michael Fried famously noted in a hostile but perceptive article, was that the Minimalist object was "theatrical": it was a presence that, by its human scale or aggressive positioning, demanded to be reckoned with by viewers as though it were another person.²⁷

While it was framed squarely in the high-art tradition, the Minimalist project is useful for thinking about everyday spaces. The physicality of the encounter with Minimalist sculpture and the ways the object manipulates the architectural space of the gallery to force viewers to respond resemble the kinds of ordinary, taken-for-granted, interactions that constitute *everyday* experience. When we confront a Minimalist sculpture we often confront a work whose maker wants "to seize and hold the space of that gallery—not simply to fill it, but seize and hold that space."²⁸ The viewer must surrender or fight back, learning something about him- or herself in the process. Anthropologists and psychologists of perception and cognition offer a concrete sense of how this happens through their investigation of human territoriality and agency. Like other animals, we humans are territorial, meaning that our daily round occupies a relatively limited and predictable range, and we tend to maintain a relatively constant personal distance—"a small protective sphere or bubble"—between ourselves and others of our species.²⁹

In humans, the formation of this buffer is an important stage in the process of self-definition. Some of our earliest forms of self-awareness arise from our understanding that we are bounded objects in a space that extends beyond us.³⁰ By differentiating self and non-self in this

elementary way, we gain a sense of agency, a realization that some but not all of the events around us can be attributed to our own thoughts and deeds.³¹ Taken together, our bodies and their protective bubbles help to define our selves by giving us an idea of “self-coherence” as physical entities with limits and the power to act and to be acted upon.³²

Yet these limits are remarkably fluid. Anthony Cohen makes a useful distinction between borders and boundaries. Borders are facts. The formal line dividing two nations is a border. Boundaries, on the other hand, are normally permeable and imprecise; they divide only to the extent that they are allowed to. National boundaries may be crossed constantly by people, languages, ideas, or goods.³³ The body appears to be defined by a clear border, the enclosing envelope of skin. But the closer one looks, the more the border appears to be a boundary, and a very fluid one at that. The environment penetrates the body, as a person breathes, eats, and drinks. More subtly, the skin itself is a permeable boundary, constantly “exchanging matter with energy.”³⁴ Our “sensorimotor space” and perceptual “receptive field,” the areas within our immediate grasp and within reach of our perception, respectively, extend our selves into a space much larger than our bodies proper, but they also make us vulnerable to the influence of the architectural and human spaces beyond our bodily boundaries.³⁵

Culture, which includes explicit and implicit propositions about daily life, shapes and amends these raw possibilities. It defines the practical limits of our territory and the social meanings of various sorts of self-colonization of space (*HD* 3; *EP* 99, 101). The goal, then, is not to discard language as an element of everyday life. As Lefebvre, inspired by his early association with the Surrealists, observed, “Living bodies, the bodies of ‘users’—are caught up not only in the toils of parcellized space, but also in the web of what philosophers call ‘analogons’: images, signs and symbols” (*PS* 98).³⁶ Practice, or kinesis, and rhetoric are inseparable.

The psychologist Ulric Neisser attempted to account for the interaction of perceptual, cognitive, and cultural data in shaping our sense of being. He cast them into five, interdependent “kinds [or modes] of self-knowledge” that range from the purely environmental and perceptual to the (almost) purely rhetorical.³⁷ The first mode, the ecological self, is dependent directly and exclusively on sensory data.³⁸ The second, the interpersonal self, provides access to other people in the same manner that the ecological self does for the nonhuman environment, for certain portions of the brain appear to be uniquely devoted to recognizing other human faces and interpreting their expressions. The three other modes are private self-knowledge, which encompasses awareness of those thoughts and experiences not available to others; extended self-knowledge, or awareness of the self’s continuity in the past and the

future; and conceptual self-knowledge, the socially given, culturally mediated, self-reflective “theory” comprising “a wide array of beliefs and assumptions” about ourselves.³⁹

At one end of the spectrum, then, is the body in primary contact with its environment. At the other is the culturally formed person understanding herself as an embodied self whose actions have observable consequences in the physical environment, but also as a social being who must modify and mediate her more private responses in acceptable ways.⁴⁰ Neisser’s model offers a way to understand the intersection of the sensory and the personal with the social and the cultural in the formation of *selfhood*, or the sense of individual identity and agency, and *personhood*, or the sense of social identity and agency.⁴¹

The navigation of everyday spaces, the ordinary, unexceptional sites of most of our sensory and intellectual experiences, is the primary arena within which selfhood and personhood are forged. In the give and take of everyday life we learn the personal and social meanings of our agency. Repeated individual actions become practices and clusters of practices become social formations. As Lefebvre observed, the “concrete, practical and alive” experience of everyday life determined the “discreteness yet inclusiveness of the individual and the social. . . . This unity is the foundation of all society: a society is made up of individuals, and the individual is a social being, in and by the content of his life and the form of his consciousness” (*CEL* 72). Pure discourse models of the everyday confront only the social side—the ways everyday life shapes social identity and agency—but a materialist account that includes *embodied* actors encompasses the inseparability of social and individual identity and agency, of what the philosopher Calvin O. Schrag calls the “we-experience” and the “I-experience” (*SP* 79).

For an example, we might turn to the early American republic, where cultural patterns transformed fundamental psychological processes in struggles over what Lefebvre called “the right to the city.”⁴² Early-nineteenth-century American media were filled with endless accounts of tobacco usage—smoking and chewing and spitting—that filled newspapers, literary essays, and visual images. Journalists spoke of the smell of cigar smoke from the streets that clung to clothing in polite parlors. Artists depicted streets full of cigar smokers and spitters of all races, classes, and ethnicities nearly smothering refined passers-by.⁴³ Tobacco represented the impingement of one’s undesirable urban neighbors on one’s own social space and identity. It epitomized the unease of many elite urbanites in the socially mixed, heavily traveled streets of the new American cities. The choice of tobacco as a metaphor for urban social and personal claustrophobia was deliberate, for the urban elite increasingly defined themselves according to a particular genteel ideal of

posture, movement, and space-holding—one that prescribed a narrowly drawn, inviolable bubble of space that would isolate each urbanite from every other one, making the streets into a collection of small, noncontiguous private spaces. Tobacco violated this.

This concern for posture is a manifestation of its central role in the human orienting system, where it helps to define the self at a particular location with respect to environment through aligning the perceptual systems in essential ways. Beyond simple orientation—Neisser's ecological self—posture is central to what cognitive scientists call the body image, the fragmented, transient sense of our bodies as they appear to our consciousness. Body images embrace our intellectual, sensate, and emotional senses of ourselves as three-dimensional objects.⁴⁴ Genteel codes idealized a body drawn in on itself and at rest that enacted *self*-control and stability and created a distinctive and unambiguous iconography of self. Its tight, predictable perimeters were of the sort most easily identifiable to the human eye. The carefully limited, closely controlled genteel body warned against intrusions on its defenses by sight or touch. The ideal was reinforced by images of its negative: of bodies slouching and dressed in exaggerated ways and smoking, all of which extended personal space beyond permissible bounds and violated others' boundaries. The genteel response was to try to open up the streets by forbidding various kinds of informal selling and other occupations of sidewalks and, when they were able to incarcerate their nemeses in prisons and asylums of various sorts, to create spaces that enforced proper postures and means of social interaction.

We can begin to understand why Lefebvre and Certeau were so interested in the power to structure space and time, for, more than regulating particular events, it is the power to shape society by governing the repetitions that form its component selves. If one could control people's movements and control their interpretation, one could control their identities.

Thus, we might conclude that the everyday is less a rhetorical field or a collection of leftover activities than a heterogeneous *mélange* of ideas, sensations, emotions, and physical actions, half-conscious and half-rote. The anthropologist Pierre Bourdieu saw this clearly. Everyday life is not a system of representations or performances, he wrote, but a "system of structured, structuring dispositions . . . which is constituted in practice and is always oriented toward practical functions."⁴⁵ He called this system the *habitus*, or practical sense. "Practical sense is a quasi-bodily involvement," he went on. It is "converted into motor schemes and body automatisms" (66, 69). Bourdieu emphasized the "disposition of the body and language to function as repositories of deferred thoughts that can be triggered off at a distance in space and time by the simple effect

of re-placing the body in an overall posture which *recalls* the associated thoughts and feelings" (69).⁴⁶ His goal was to salvage the structuralist concept of culture while responding to criticisms of structuralism's inability to account for change by stressing that the *habitus* is only a predisposition, "a present past that tends to perpetuate itself into the future," a way to proceed lodged in an actor capable of thinking and making judgments, so that in "the necessary yet unpredictable confrontation between the *habitus* and an event," new solutions are improvised. As both a sensorimotor *and* an ideological quality, the *habitus* is a flexible disposition that allow one to act in a way that is at once habitual *and* improvisatory, rote *and* novel. It is above all an "art of inventing" (54–56).

And so we arrive at a more concrete sense of the everyday, in every sense of the word. One definition of everyday life might be "The nexus of spaces and times that repeatedly trigger bodily habits and cultural memories—the *habitus*." Everyday life can be oppressive or liberating, depending on the ways it is organized temporally and spatially. Everyday life shapes selfhood and personhood through material, and particularly bodily, practices, but its critical quality is time, as Michel de Certeau realized. It is the repetition and routine of everyday life that teaches our bodies the *habitus*. So the power to organize space and time, to articulate Certeau's "organizing discourse," those qualities of modernity that Lefebvre identified as sources of the banality and alienation of everyday life in the modern world, gives considerable power to shape self and society. As Bourdieu observed, "Symbolic power works partly through the control of other people's bodies and belief that is given by the collectively recognized capacity to act in various ways on deep-rooted linguistic and muscular patterns of behaviour" (69). But the unpredictability of the *habitus* means that no one can *control* the everyday.

So if we understand what the everyday is, we can also understand *how* it works: through bodily memory instilled by repeated action in organized time and space. This definition gives the everyday a specificity that is lacking in the work of Lefebvre and Certeau and their architectural disciples, and it suggests as well why small-*a* architecture is critical to understanding everyday life.

It also does something important for architecture itself, reincorporating Architecture into the larger landscape. The *habitus* as both a "structured, structuring disposition" *and* an "art of inventing" also accounts both for pattern and continuity and for improvisation and change. It reunites the ordinary and the extraordinary as inseparable aspects of experience, neither possible without the other, neither determining the other. In building an understanding of this sort from the routine and ordinary, we can ultimately relinquish the concept of the

everyday. In the small field of Architecture and architectural studies, for example, we can examine the cultural landscape without recourse to the hierarchies and oppositions of high and low that impede understanding and have fragmented the field for many years into advocates for and scholars of “high” and “low” architecture, Architecture and architecture, each with its own values, goals, and methods.

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NOTES

- 1 Henri Lefebvre, *Everyday Life in the Modern World*, tr. Sacha Rabinovitch (New Brunswick, N.J., 1984), pp. 14, 8; hereafter cited in text as *EL*.
- 2 Henri Lefebvre, “The Everyday and Everydayness,” in *Architecture of the Everyday*, ed. Steven Harris and Deborah Berke (New York, 1997), p. 34.
- 3 Steven Harris, “Everyday Architecture,” in *Architecture of the Everyday*, p. 3; hereafter cited in text as EA.
- 4 Margaret Crawford, “Introduction” to *Everyday Urbanism*, ed. John Chase, Margaret Crawford, and John Kaliski (New York, 1999), p. 9; hereafter cited in text as IEU.
- 5 Henry-Russell Hitchcock Jr. and Philip Johnson, *The International Style: Architecture Since 1922* (New York, 1932); Sigfried Giedion, *Space, Time and Architecture: The Growth of a New Tradition* (Cambridge, Mass., 1941); Bruno Zevi, *Architecture as Space: How to Look at Architecture* (New York, 1957).
- 6 Henri Lefebvre, *The Production of Space* [1974], tr. Donald Nicholson-Smith (Oxford, 1991); hereafter cited in text as PS. For an important discussion of Lefebvre’s relevance to Architecture, see Mary McLeod, “Henri Lefebvre’s Critique of Everyday Life: An Introduction,” in *Architecture of the Everyday*, pp. 9–29.
- 7 Gwendolyn Wright eloquently describes one episode in the struggle between architects and builders in *Moralism and the Model Home: Domestic Architecture and Cultural Conflict in Chicago, 1873–1913* (Chicago, 1980), pp. 40–78.
- 8 Magali Sarfatti Larson, *The Rise of Professionalism: A Sociological Analysis* (Berkeley, 1977), pp. 15–18, 24, 38.
- 9 Nikolaus Pevsner, *An Outline of European Architecture*, 7th ed. (Harmondsworth, 1970), p. 15.
- 10 Bernard Rudofsky, *Architecture without Architects: A Short Introduction to Non-Pedigreed Architecture* (New York, 1964); Felicity Scott, “Bernard Rudofsky: Allegories of Nomadism and Dwelling,” in *Anxious Modernisms: Experimentation in Postwar Architectural Culture*, ed. Sarah Williams Goldhagen and Réjean Legault (Cambridge, Mass., 2000), p. 215. Rudofsky’s book remains in print, having defined the exotic realm of “the vernacular” for several generations of Architectural teachers and students now.
- 11 Denise Scott Brown, “Learning from Pop” [1971], in Robert Venturi and Denise Scott Brown, *A View from the Campidoglio: Selected Essays, 1953–1984*, ed. Peter Arnell, Ted Bickford, and Catherine Bergart (New York, 1984), p. 27.
- 12 Robert Venturi, Denise Scott Brown, and Steven Izenour, *Learning from Las Vegas: The Forgotten Symbolism of Architectural Form*, rev. ed. (Cambridge, Mass., 1977), p. 3; hereafter cited in text as *LV*. On Venturi and Scott Brown’s implied claims for the superior authenticity of popular aesthetics, see Deborah Fausch, “Ugly and Ordinary: The Representation of the Everyday,” in *Architecture of the Everyday*, p. 104.
- 13 Sarah Wigglesworth and Jeremy Till, “The Everyday and Architecture,” in *The Everyday*

and *Architecture*, no. 134 of *Architectural Design Profile*, ed. Wigglesworth and Till (London, 1998), p. 7; hereafter cited in text as EVA.

14 Denise Scott Brown, "Pop Off: Reply to Kenneth Frampton" [1971], in *View from the Campidoglio*, p. 34; hereafter cited in text as PO.

15 John Friedmann, "The City of Everyday Life: Knowledge/Power and the Problem of Representation," *DISP*, 136 (1999), 8.

16 For a discussion of Lefebvre's notion of the extraordinary embedded in the ordinary, see McLeod, "Henri Lefebvre's Critique of Everyday Life," pp. 13, 19; Rob Shields, *Lefebvre, Love and Struggle: Spatial Dialectics* (London, 1999), p. 71; hereafter cited in text as *LL*.

17 Michel de Certeau, *The Practice of Everyday Life*, tr. Steven Rendell (Berkeley, 1984), p. 48; hereafter cited in text as *PEL*.

18 Henri Lefebvre, *Critique of Everyday Life*, tr. John Moore, vol. 1 (London, 1991), p. 182. Italics in the original. Hereafter cited in text as *CEL*.

19 Le Corbusier, *Towards a New Architecture*, tr. Frederick Etchells (New York, 1960), pp. 23–24.

20 Norman Millar, "Street Survival: The Plight of the Los Angeles Vendors," in *Everyday Urbanism*, pp. 136–51; John Chase, "The Giant Revolving (Winking) Chicken Head and the Doggie Drinking Fountain: Making Small Public Spaces on Private Land by Using Commonplace Objects," in *Everyday Urbanism*, pp. 110–19; Níall McLaughlin, "Shack, Foxhall, Northamptonshire," in *The Everyday and Architecture*, pp. 42–47; Phillip Hall-Patch, "Breaking the Veil," in *The Everyday and Architecture*, pp. 36–39; Günther Behnisch, "Circumstantial Architecture," in *The Everyday and Architecture*, pp. 88–95.

21 Joan Ockman, "Toward a Theory of Normative Architecture," in *Architecture of the Everyday*, p. 123. Ockman credits the notion of a major and minor architecture to Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari.

22 On semiotics: Venturi, Scott Brown, and Izenour, *Learning from Las Vegas*; and Charles Jencks and George Baird, ed., *Meaning in Architecture* (New York, 1970). On generative grammar: Henry Glassie, *Folk Housing in Middle Virginia: A Structural Analysis of Historic Artifacts* (Knoxville, 1975). On deconstruction: Christopher Norris and Andrew Benjamin, *What Is Deconstruction?* (London, 1988); Michael Benedikt, *Deconstructing the Kimbell: An Essay on Meaning and Architecture* (New York, 1991); Mark Wigley, *The Architecture of Deconstruction: Derrida's Haunt* (Cambridge, Mass., 1993). For a current example of the normative use of a discourse model, see Sarah Williams Goldhagen's characterization of Louis Kahn's buildings as "intertexts" and "powerful aesthetic propositions." (Sarah Williams Goldhagen, *Louis Kahn's Situated Modernism* [New Haven, 2001], p. 5.)

23 John Dewey, *Art as Experience* [1934] (New York, 1979), pp. 24, 47.

24 Bruce Glaser, "Questions to Stella and Judd" [1966], in *Minimal Art: A Critical Anthology*, ed. Gregory Battcock (Berkeley, 1995), p. 155; Donald Judd, "Specific Objects" [1965], in *Minimalism*, ed. James Meyer (New York, 2000), pp. 207–10.

25 James Meyer, *Minimalism: Art and Polemics in the Sixties* (New Haven, 2001), p. 24.

26 Robert Morris, "Notes on Sculpture, Part II" [1966], in *Continuous Project Altered Daily: The Writings of Robert Morris* (Cambridge, Mass., 1993), p. 11.

27 Michael Fried, "Art and Objecthood" [1967], in *Minimal Art*, pp. 116–47. The art historian James Meyer notes that Morris's own sculpture "orchestrated a choreographed movement around the work and the gallery. . . . the Morris [work] was to be experienced by an ambient body that walked around, and through, the work itself." (Meyer, *Minimalism*, p. 51.)

28 Carl Andre, quoted in Anna C. Chave, "Minimalism and the Rhetoric of Power," *Arts Magazine*, 64 (1990), 44.

29 Edward T. Hall, *The Hidden Dimension* (Garden City, N.Y., 1969), p. 119; hereafter cited in text as *HD*. See also pp. 7, 10, 66.

- 30 Naomi Eilan, Anthony Marcel, and José Luis Bermúdez, "Self-Consciousness and the Body: An Interdisciplinary Introduction," in *The Body and the Self*, ed. José Luis Bermúdez, Anthony Marcel, and Naomi Eilan (Cambridge, Mass., 1995), p. 20.
- 31 Celia A. Brownell and Claire B. Kopp, "Common Threads, Diverse Solutions: Concluding Commentary," *Developmental Review*, 11 (1991), 297; John Campbell, "The Body Image and Self-Consciousness," in *The Body and the Self*, p. 34.
- 32 George Butterworth, "An Ecological Perspective on the Origins of Self," in *The Body and the Self*, p. 101; hereafter cited in text as EP.
- 33 Anthony P. Cohen, *Self-Consciousness: An Alternative Anthropology of Identity* (London, 1994), pp. 122–32.
- 34 James J. Gibson, *The Senses Considered as Perceptual Systems* (Boston, 1966), pp. 18–19.
- 35 Jacques Paillard, "Motor and Representational Framing of Space," in *Brain and Space*, ed. Jacques Paillard (Oxford, 1991), p. 164.
- 36 On Lefebvre's connection with surrealism, see Shields, *Lefebvre*, pp. 71, 76, 155; Gardiner, *Critiques of Everyday Life*, pp. 72–73, 82–83.
- 37 Ulric Neisser, "Five Kinds of Self-Knowledge," *Philosophical Psychology*, 1 (1988), 35–59.
- 38 Neisser's term "ecological" was borrowed from James J. Gibson, whose work underpins much of the contemporary philosophical and psychological work on selfhood. Gibson stressed the ways that evolution had given animate beings direct access to necessary information from their environments; the capacity is built into human (and other beings') sensorimotor systems and requires no cultural information or even life experience to shape it. His most famous examples were drawn from the optical structure of the world. Gibson showed that animate beings' visual systems were attuned to the environmental phenomena of "looming," in which objects directly in front of us appear to grow larger as we approach; of occlusion, in which one object appears to disappear as it passes behind another; and of "optical flow," the continuous "streaming" of peripheral visual images as we move through space. These map a unique point of view, Neisser's ecological self, at their intersection. (James J. Gibson, *The Ecological Approach to Visual Perception* [Boston, 1979], pp. 78–86, 103–4, 227–29).
- 39 Ulric Neisser, "The Self Perceived," in *The Perceived Self: Ecological and Interpersonal Sources of Self-Knowledge*, ed. Ulric Neisser (Cambridge, 1993), p. 4.
- 40 Calvin O. Schrag, *The Self after Postmodernity* (New Haven, 1997), p. 61; hereafter cited in text as *SP*.
- 41 I borrow the concepts "selfhood" and "personhood" from Cohen, *Self-Consciousness*.
- 42 Henri Lefebvre, "The Right to the City," in *Writings on Cities*, tr. and ed. Eleonore Kofman and Elizabeth Lebas (Oxford, 1996), pp. 63–181.
- 43 For a fuller discussion of urban tobacco use, see Dell Upton, "Inventing the Metropolis: Civilization and Urbanity in Antebellum New York," in *Art and the Empire City: New York, 1825–1861*, ed. Catherine Hoover Voorsanger and John K. Howat (New York, 2000), pp. 33–34.
- 44 Shaun Gallagher, "Body Image and Body Schema: A Conceptual Clarification," *Journal of Mind and Behavior*, 7 (1986), 546, 548.
- 45 Pierre Bourdieu, *The Logic of Practice*, tr. Richard Nice (Stanford, 1990), p. 52; hereafter cited in text.
- 46 Physiologists and anthropologists have made similar observations about the ways particular sensory experiences trigger particular emotions or memories simply as a product of the idiosyncratic wiring of the human brain. See for example Rodney Needham, "Percussion and Transition," *Man*, 2 (1967), 606–14; Michael Davis, "The Role of the Amygdala in Fear and Anxiety," *Annual Review of Neuroscience*, 15 (1992), 353–75.

